



3 Comparative essay: theme across two works (Paper 2)

Paper 2 · Comparative essay · IB Diploma · Concept guide and original exam-style practice

Understand the concept

Paper 2 requires an essay that compares and contrasts at least two of the works studied in response to an essay question, usually organised around a shared theme, motif, or concern. A strong comparative essay is structured around ideas (not work-by-work summary), moving fluidly between texts within each paragraph to show genuine comparison, and it uses each work's differing treatment of the theme to sharpen the overall argument.

Worked example: follow the reasoning

Essay question: Compare how two works you have studied explore the theme of belonging. Model thesis: 'While one work presents belonging as something achieved through deliberate self-transformation, the other presents it as an illusion sustained only by the community's silence about difference; both works, however, suggest that belonging is fundamentally performative rather than natural.' This thesis names a genuine point of comparison and contrast, giving the essay a clear analytical spine rather than two separate summaries.

Quick check · multiple choice

Which structural approach is generally considered weakest for a Paper 2 comparative essay?
A Organising paragraphs by idea, drawing on both works within each paragraph
B Writing one half of the essay entirely on Work A and the other half entirely on Work B
C Opening with a thesis that identifies both a similarity and a difference between the works
D Using topic sentences that signal the comparative point of each paragraph

Write your choice: _____

Structured practice

Answer in the space provided.

- 1 Using two generic literary forms and works you have studied (for example, two novels, or a novel and a play), write a comparative essay plan responding to the question: 'Compare the ways two works you have studied present the relationship between power and silence.' Do not name real texts in your answer; instead outline the comparative argument using placeholder descriptions of the works' content. [20]

Final answer: _____



Answers and explanation

Question 1 [20]

Introduction: thesis contrasting two different functions of silence (e.g. silence as submission vs silence as resistance) in relation to power.

- Body 1: compare how each work establishes an initial power imbalance and the narrative or dramatic techniques used to signal it (e.g. dialogue patterns, narrative voice, staging).
- Body 2: compare a turning point in each work where silence shifts meaning (from submission to resistance, or vice versa), analysing specific textual/technical evidence from both works in the same paragraph.
- Body 3: compare the ultimate authorial stance suggested by each work's ending — does silence get rewarded, punished, or left ambiguous — and what this suggests about each writer's view of power.
- Conclusion: synthesise the comparison into a broader claim about how form (novel vs play, or differing narrative techniques) shapes each work's treatment of the shared theme.

Quick check answer

B. A 'block' structure (all of Work A, then all of Work B) tends to produce parallel summaries rather than sustained comparison, which examiners reward less than integrated analysis.

Self-assessment

Compare each credited step with your own answer. Fix the first reasoning or content error, then retry the practice question without looking at the solution.

Based on the IB English A: Literature guide (2019).

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